

MOROCCAN TEA CULTURE

The custom of drinking sweet green tea infused with mint originated in Morocco in the 19th century, when Gunpowder tea was introduced by British merchants. In just 150 years, tea drinking has become an intrinsic part of Moroccan culture.

Moroccan mint tea, also known as Maghrebi tea, is popular in the Maghreb region of Tunisia, Algeria, and Morocco. It is prepared using Gunpowder green tea, which was first imported to Morocco in the 1860s. The Moroccans soon found that, when mixed with mint and sugar, it made a refreshing, aromatic drink.

In northern Africa, tea is always the first order of business, and it is customary to make tea for guests in honor of their visit. Unlike Maghrebi food, which is usually prepared by women, tea is brewed and served by the man of the house. It is considered impolite to refuse an offer of tea.

The host begins by rinsing two tablespoons of Gunpowder tea leaves in a teapot with boiling water. This reduces the bitterness of the tea. Next, he adds up to 12 cubes of

sugar to the teapot and infuses the leaves with 3½ cups of boiling water for 15 minutes. This produces a very strong tea, which helps to explain why so much sugar is used. The tea is strained into a second metal teapot and brought to a boil before the sugar is added. When the tea is ready, handfuls of fresh mint leaves are placed in the traditional jewel-colored glasses known as “keesan”. Finally, the tea is poured with a flourish from a height of about 24in (60cm) to aerate the tea and create froth.

Traditionally, tea is served three times, imparting a different flavor each time as the leaves continue to steep. As an old proverb says, “The first glass is gentle as life; the second glass is as strong as love; the third glass is as bitter as death.”

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FLAVOR OF THE TEA

